

Getting a Thumbs Up

While the Indo-US nuclear deal is given a go-ahead, the Government gets a pat for its handling of cross-border terrorism and relations with Pakistan

Manmohan Singh can take heart with the results of the poll where foreign policy is concerned. A majority of those surveyed felt that his Government had done a good job on tackling cross-border terrorism and remained optimistic about the peace process with Pakistan. This despite Opposition parties criticising the Government for its poor handling of issues concerning terrorism. Indicating their confidence in the Government's approach, again a majority believed that the chances of a war with Pakistan were extremely low.

On another critical foreign policy issue—the Indo-US nuclear deal—the balance clearly tips in favour of the

Government going ahead with the deal, though some did lay down a caveat of ensuring that there is a consensus among political parties for it. However, despite the many hours spent on debating the subject in Parliament, the level of awareness about the deal remains low. Also in terms of people's priority, foreign affairs issues continue to figure way below unemployment and rising prices. While the Government's handling of foreign policy continues to be viewed positively, with the deal running into trouble, 34 per cent rated its overall performance as average while 29 per cent marked it as good to outstanding. Actions do speak louder than words. **by Raj Chengappa**



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